Wanchoos. That rapport was one of the primary reasons for our success subsequently.

This was achieved by our exemplary conduct and people-friendly activities. While the insurgents were away from Nagaland for about a year, the security environment of the remote Indo-Burmese region in Tuensang district changed drastically. There was much greater presence of the army along the border and more effective surveillance. Besides, we had won over the hearts and minds of the people. A mistake made by the leaders of the insurgents was that they had included very few men from the border tribes, whom they considered inferior to their own tribes from the heartland. That attitude hurt the pride of these border tribes. As a result they willingly cooperated with us and provided very valuable information and logistical help where required. News kept trickling in of the return of the gang led by Mowu Angami, Issac Swu and T. Muivah. But the question on everyone's mind was when, and from where, will they re-enter Nagaland? We were palpably nervous and anxious.

On 2 or 3 March 1969, I was asked by the CO to take out a patrol and go right upto the border on the top of the Patkai range, carry out surveillance, and try and get some specific information on the gang. I left for my mission by the afternoon with a mixed group of soldiers from my battalion and 8 Assam Rifles. Very early the next morning, we reached the highest point of the mountain. There the track meandered on a plateau covered with a thick forest. It was a kind of a 'no-man's-land'. As we crept forward, the track began to descend sharply. I wasn't sure of our position, and besides, in those days, we had no GPS to help us out either. Going down the steep slope in the jungle as silently as we could, we suddenly heard noises. We froze at once. I went up to the leading scout and, from the cover of a large tree trunk, saw an incredible sight. There were about fifteen to twenty armed men. It was difficult to make out whether they were Burmese Army soldiers or members of the insurgent gang! I had about ten soldiers and most of them were from Assam Rifles. There was no possibility of ascertaining the identity of these aliens. Further, if they noticed us they wouldn't let